THE SHE LIST
UNDER 50

Lighting Up the Stage

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Sanya's gripping performance in the 2025 domestic drama, *Mrs*, and kicking off her entrepreneurial journey with a matcha brand

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

Rome wasn't built in a day. Twelve years back, that's what Sanya Malhotra's dad had told her as she struggled to find a toehold in the Mumbai film industry. Today, Sanya is everywhere; from making women open up about their marital woes after watching her character struggle in *Mrs* (2025), to putting up reels about her matcha brand, to winning hearts with her moves in Diljit Dosanjh's 'Charmer'.

Malhotra senses the seismic shift in her career after *Mrs*, one of the most-watched dramas on streaming last year. It sees her play a new bride who faces the humiliating brunt of patriarchy, most of it unfolding in the kitchen. "Before it, I was a confident actor, but I was still figuring it out. Now, I can do films that I am front-lining and make them work," she says. "The audience had more confidence in me than I had in myself." Its success has also emboldened Sanya. "I want to make bolder choices. I don't want to hold back," she says. "Now I want to do what I haven't done before." Proof of that is *Sunder Poonam*, a slated-for-2027 Amazon film in which she plays a woman "she couldn't empathise or sympathise with at all".

HER TAKE

"When *Mrs* released, people made reels, I got letters and DMs from women who related to Richa's story. I felt, 'This is it'."

Sanya has come a long way since she made her debut in the blockbuster *Dangal* (2016). It has been a journey where failure was necessary to find her groove. "I did a few films just for eyeballs. In hindsight, I could've avoided them. But it's good I didn't. How would I learn otherwise?" There is greater awareness of what she wants now. Sanya doesn't let balancing between theatrical and OTT titles consume her or the pressure of building an audience faze her. "When I love a script and a character," she says, "I am freer and more comfortable." ■

— Suhani Singh